

Usability Testing

Part of **UI/UX Design Principles** · Estimated time: 35 min

Introduction

Usability testing means watching a real person attempt a task on your design and paying attention to what they actually do, not just what they say afterward.

Core ideas

- Jakob Nielsen's well-known finding is that testing with about five users typically surfaces most major usability problems — you don't need dozens of participants to learn a lot.
- The think-aloud protocol asks participants to narrate their thoughts as they work, which surfaces confusion in the moment rather than in a memory-shaped summary afterward.
- Give participants a specific, realistic task ("find this product and add it to your cart") instead of an open-ended "explore the site."
- Hesitation, backtracking, and re-reading are all signals worth writing down, even if the participant eventually completes the task.

Try it yourself

Ask a friend to complete one specific task using an app or website you use often, while thinking out loud, and just watch — don't help. Write down every moment they hesitated or backtracked.

Further reading

- Nielsen Norman Group — Usability Testing 101

<https://www.nngroup.com/articles/usability-testing-101/>

- Usability.gov — Usability Testing

<https://www.usability.gov/how-to-and-tools/methods/usability-testing.html>

ModuloTrainer reading material — return to the app to mark this module complete.